Curriculum Vitae

Qian Cao

Department of Philosophy
Columbia University
1150 Amsterdam Ave,
New York, NY 10027 USA

Email: qc2255@columbia.edu

Website: qiancaophil.github.io

Area of Specialization (AOS): Ancient Greek and Roman Philosophy, Psychoanalysis

Area of Competence (AOC): Ethics, Classical Chinese Philosophy, History of Early Modern Philosophy

EMPLOYMENT

COLUMBIA UNIVERSITY

Postdoctoral Research Scholar and Lecturer, the Initiative in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy 2025-Present

EDUCATION

COLUMBIA UNIVERSITY
New York, NY
Ph.D. in Philosophy October 2025
Dissertation: Appearance and Reality—Plato and the Psychological Difficulties of Inquiry
Committee: Katja Vogt (Chair), Dhananjay Jagannathan, Achille Varzi, Francey Russell, Jessica Moss (external examiner)

Abstract (an extended version is at the end of the c.v.): What, for Plato, makes inquiry difficult? This question has been explored with a view to Plato's metaphysics. Our engrossment in the sense perceptible domain—characterized by its instability and deceptiveness—makes it difficult for us to attend to intelligible reality and often leads us astray. In addition, I argue, Plato is interested in the psychological challenges of inquiry. I examine famous as well as neglected passages in *Cratylus*, *Republic*, and *Theaetetus*—on relativism, *doxa*, education, and mathematics—and draw on psychoanalytic contributions that, in my view, help elucidate how Plato conceives of the conflation of appearances with reality.

M.Phil. in Philosophy May 2021
M.A. in Philosophy May 2020

INSTITUTE FOR PSYCHOANALYTIC TRAINING AND RESEARCH (IPTAR)
New York, NY 2022-Present
Advanced candidate in the Adult Program & the Child and Adolescent Program (CAP)

NEW YORK UNIVERSITY
New York, NY
Bachelor of Arts in Philosophy May 2017

- **Honors**: Phi Beta Kappa, and High Honors in Philosophy
- **Honors Thesis***: Aristotle on the Voluntary and* Prohairesis (Advisor: Jessica Moss)

PUBLICATION AND PAPERS

"Plato on Dizziness, Projection, and the Psychology of Relativism," *Rhizomata—A Journal for Ancient Philosophy and Science*, forthcoming.

"Mathematics, Play, and Reality in the *Republic*" (Under Review)

"Hide and Seek: The Wish to Be Sought and Found in the Treatment of a Latency-Aged Child" (Under Review)

"The Paradox of the Measure: Measure Doctrine and Immediate Sense Perception in the *Theaetetus*" (Complete Draft)

"Different Audience of Imitative Poetry: A Tale of Human Psychology in *Republic* Books 3 and 10" (In Progress)

"Plato and Why Perception Fails to Reach Truth and Being" (In Progress)

"Guilt, Need for Punishment, and Moral Responsibility" (In Progress)

"Relating to Reality—Hans Loewald and the Defense Against the Loss of Reality" (In Progress)

FELLOWSHIPS & AWARDS

2025-2028	Core Curriculum Postdoctoral Lectureship in Contemporary Civilization, Columbia University **Awarded. (Declined in order to accept the postdoctoral position with the Initiative in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy)*
2024-2025	Core Curriculum Preceptorship in Contemporary Civilization, Columbia University
2022	Center for the Ancient Mediterranean Summer Research Fund ($1,000), Columbia University
2021-2022	Teaching Observation Fellowship, Center for Teaching & Learning, Columbia University
2019-2022	Benjamin Wolstein Fellowship, Columbia University
2021-2022	Columbia Tutor Corps Operations Fellow, Office of Public Affairs/Government & Community Affairs

PRESENTATIONS

December 2026	"Protagorean Relativism About Sense-Perception," *The Undergraduate Open House*, Columbia University
April 2026	"Psychic Flux and Transformation in Plato," *The Meade Anderson Forum in Philosophy Conference*, Columbia University
March 2026	"Measure Doctrine and Immediate Sense Perception in the *Theaetetus*," *Workshop in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University
March 2026	"Hide and Seek: The Wish to Be Sought and Found in the Treatment of a Latency-Aged Child," *Rebecca Shaffer Memorial Lecture*, Institute for Psychoanalytic Training and Research (IPTAR)
February 2026	"Hans Loewald's 'Man as Moral Agent'," Invited Guest Lecture for *Living, Dying, and the Meaning of Life* class, Columbia University
November 2025	"Mathematics, Play and Reality in Plato's *Republic,*" APS Graduate Panel, *The Ancient Philosophy Society*
August 2025	"An Account of Why Perception Fails to Reach Truth and Being in the *Theaetetus*," *End-of-Summer Workshop*, Columbia University

August 2024	"Mathematics, Play, and Reality—on the Difficulty of Turning the Soul Around in the *Republic*", *Research Group in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University
July 2024	"Plato on Dizziness, Projection, and the Psychology of Relativism", *Athena in Action: A Networking and Mentoring Workshop for Graduate Student Women in Philosophy*, University of Notre Dame
March 2024	"Plato on Dizziness, Projection, and the Psychology of Relativism", *Keeling Graduate & Early Career Conference in Ancient Philosophy*, University College London, United Kingdom
August 2023	"Different Audience of Imitative Poetry: A Tale of Human Psychology in *Republic* Books 3 and 10", *End-of-Summer Workshop*, Columbia University
June 2023	"Collective Appearances, Individual *Psyche*, and Collective Responsibility", *The Aristotle-Confucius Symposium on Ethics for the 21st Century*, a week-long conference held at Academy of Athens and at Aristotle University of Thessaloniki
October 2022	"On the Difficulty of Turning the Soul Around in the *Republic*", presentation in Katja Vogt's graduate seminar, Columbia University
July 2022	"Plato and the Appeal of Relativism", *Graduate Students Workshop*, University of Colorado, Boulder
March 2022	"Plato and the Appeal of Relativism", *Ancient Philosophy WIP Workshop*, New York University
October 2021	"The Meno Problem", guest lecture in Katja Vogt's undergraduate class, Columbia University
August 2021	"Plato on the Descriptive and Dynamic Use of Language", *Research Group in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University
August 2020	"Language and Reality in the *Cratylus*: Correctness as Imitation", *Research Group in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University
August 2019	"The Skeptics' Non-Doxastic Assent as an Alternative to Holding *Dogmata*—A Reading Through the Lens of Plato", *Research Group in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University
January 2019	(with Mariana Beatriz-Noe, Olivia Branscum, and Yarran Hominh) "Mutual Skill-Building through Undergraduate Writing Workshops", MAP Panel on Skill-Building and Improving the Profession, Eastern APA

INVITED COMMENTS AND SESSION CHAIRING

November 2026	Session Chair, Classical Dialogues with David Sider on Parmenides, *Classical Dialogues*, Columbia University
February 2026	Session Chair, Mitzi Lee "Justice as a Virtue in Aristotle's Ethics" and Merrick Anderson "Tatters to Tyranny Observation' and Plato's Final Response to the Appeal of Injustice," *Workshop in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*
February 2025	Session Chair, Parmenides and the Way of Truth with David Sedley and Shaul Tor, *Workshop in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University
October 2022	Comment on Catherine Rowett, "Platonic Method", *Workshop in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University

February 2022	Comment on Amber Carpenter, "Ethics of Atomism", *Lecture Series of Center for the Ancient Mediterranean*, Columbia University
March 2021	Comment on Suzanne Obdrzalek, "Platonic Dualism Reconsidered", *Workshop in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University
April 2020	Comment on Molly Gordon Pinkoski, "Aristotelian Absolute Prohibitions", in Dhananjay Jagannathan's graduate seminar, Columbia University
March 2020	Comment on Hadassa Noorda, "Exprisonment: Deprivation of Liberty on the Street and at Home", *Munich-New York City Workshop in Ethics*, Columbia University
March 2019	Comment on Klaus Corcilius, "Cosmological ethics and internal order in the Timaeus", *Workshop in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University
November 2018	Comment on James Doyle, "No Morality: Modern Moral Philosophy (1958)", *Workshop in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University

TEACHING

Co-leader, Columbia University

Fall 2026	Ancient Greek Philosophy Reading Group – Empedocles

Instructor of Record, Columbia University

Fall 2025	History of Philosophy I - Pre-Socratics through Augustine, Philosophy
Spring 2025	Contemporary Civilization II, Core Curriculum
Fall 2024	Contemporary Civilization I, Core Curriculum
Summer 2024	Ethics, Philosophy

Teaching Assistant (TA), Columbia University

Spring 2024	Living, Dying, and the Meaning of Life (Katja Vogt, Lydia Dugdale, and Ian Rottenberg)
Fall 2023	History of Philosophy I - Pre-Socratics through Augustine (Dhananjay Jagannathan)
Spring 2022	History of Philosophy II - Medieval and Early Modern Philosophy (Christina Van Dyke)
Fall 2021	History of Philosophy I - Pre-Socratics through Augustine (Katja Vogt)
Spring 2021	Introduction to Philosophy (Francey Russell)
Fall 2020	Philosophy of Law (Michele Moody-Adams)
Spring 2020	Introduction to Philosophy (Francey Russell)
Fall 2019	Feminism and Philosophy (Christia Mercer)

Co-Facilitator, *RETHINK*, a Columbia philosophy community outreach program

Summer 2022	Co-led a series of discussions centering around the theme of "Happiness" to a group of youth affected by the criminal legal system

Instructor of Record, *BIG QUESTIONS,* a NYU-led outreach program for high schools

2015-2018	— Led weekly philosophy discussion in both English and Mandarin for a group of 20 high school students; — Led discussion on "Big Questions," including freedom and determinism, Responsibility and Determinism, Personal Identity, Happiness, Equality, Right and Wrong, and Animal Rights; — Designed lesson plans to introduce students to philosophical questions in Confucian ethics

PEDAGOGICAL TRAINING

2021-2022	As a Teaching Observation Fellow with Columbia Center for Teaching and Learning (CTL), I worked closely other fellows from different disciplines to build skills in teaching observation, formative assessment, inclusive teaching, and peer mentorship.
2020	Innovative Teaching Summer Institute (ITSI), Columbia Center for Teaching and Learning (CTL), Columbia University

SERVICE TO THE PROFESSION

2024-2026	Referee for *Archiv für Geschichte der Philosophie*
2023-2026	Referee for *Noûs*
2020-2023	Assistant Managing Editor for North America, *Archiv für Geschichte der Philosophie*
2021-2022	Graduate Student Representative, Columbia University Philosophy Department
2018-2022	Co-organizer, Columbia University MAP (Minority and Philosophy) Chapter
2018-2022	Organizer, Non-Western Philosophy Reading Group, Columbia University
2021	Organizer, "Life of a Paper" talk series, Columbia University Philosophy Department
2018-2021	Workshop leader of the *Reading & Writing Philosophy Workshop*, organized by the Minorities and Philosophy (MAP) chapter, Columbia University
2019	Co-organizer, Columbia-NYU Graduate Conference in Philosophy
2018	Judge, NYC High School Ethics Bowl

GRADUATE COURSEWORK

**indicates audit*

Ancient Philosophy

Plato's *Republic*, Katja Vogt
Protagoras, Wolfgang Mann
Hellenistic Philosophy: Ancient Relativism and Skepticism, Katja Vogt
Aristotelian Naturalisms, Dhananjay Jagannathan
Plato, Katja Vogt
*** Early Stoic Philosophy: Logic, Physics, and Ethics**, Katja Vogt
Plato's *Timaeus*, Katja Vogt
*** Practical Wisdom in Plato and Aristotle**, Jessica Moss and Iakovos Vasiliou (NYU)
*** Plato**, Jessica Moss (NYU)
Democracy and Its Discontents in Late Fifth-century Athens, Elizabeth Scharffenberger (Classics)

*** Aristotle**, Katja Vogt
*** Ancient Epistemology**, Jessica Moss (NYU)
Theophrastus, Wolfgang Mann
*** Lucretius**, Wolfgang Mann

Other Courses

Self-Knowledge, Akeel Bilgrami
Self-Opacity and Human Agency, Francey Russell
Symbolic Logic, Tamar Lando
Metaethics: What, if Anything, Is Morality?, Katja Vogt
Democratic Citizenship: Problems and Possibilities, Michele Moody-Adams
*** Kant**, Patricia Kitcher
Kant's Ethics, Patricia Kitcher
Feminist, Social, and Political Philosophy of Language, Karen Lewis
Metaethics: **The Value of Truth**, Katja Vogt
Boundaries — from Politics to Metaphysics (and back), Achille Varzi
Heidegger, Taylor Carman
*** Buddhist Ethics**, Graham Priest (CUNY)
*** Classical Chinese Philosophy**, Hagop Sakissian (CUNY)

LANGUAGES

Ancient: Greek (scholarly proficient), Classical Chinese (intermediate)

Modern: English (fluent), Mandarin Chinese (fluent), Italian (intermediate)

REFERENCES

Katja Vogt, Professor of Philosophy, Columbia University
kv2101@columbia.edu

Jessica Moss, Professor of Philosophy, New York University
jm5706@nyu.edu

Amber Carpenter, Professor of Ancient Philosophy, Oxford University
amber.carpenter@philosophy.ox.ac.uk

Mi-Kyoung (Mitzi) Lee, Associate Professor of Philosophy, University of Colorado at Boulder
mitzi.lee@colorado.edu

Dhananjay Jagannathan, Associate Professor of Philosophy, Hunter College — City University of New York
dhananjay.jagannathan@hunter.cuny.edu

Michele Moody-Adams, Professor of Philosophy, Columbia University (Teaching Reference)
mm3735@columbia.edu

Francey Russell, Assistant Professor of Philosophy, Barnard College and Columbia University
frussell@barnard.edu

Last Updated: Oct 28, 2026